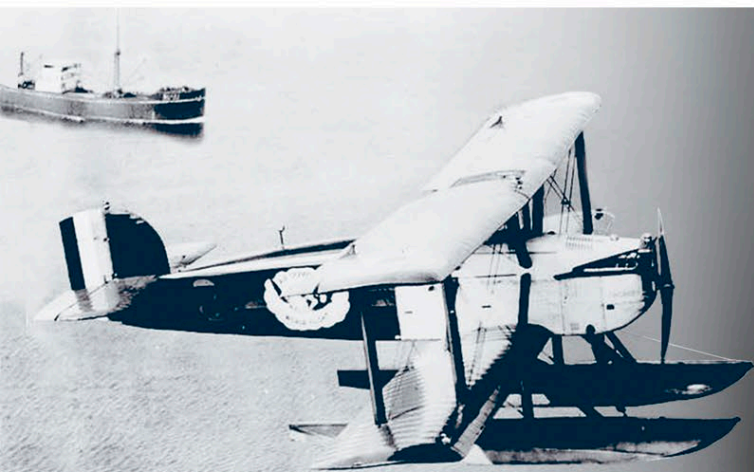




A Douglas World Cruiser with floats successfully flew round the world in 1924

Great Manufacturers Douglas

The Douglas Aircraft Company was established by Donald Douglas in 1921 and went on to become a multimillion dollar business. Responsible for producing the most important propeller-driven transport of all time, the DC-3, it is also known for its fighters, bombers, and supersonic research aircraft.

LIKE OTHER AVIATION pioneers, Donald Douglas was inspired by the Wright brothers—he witnessed their aircraft demonstration at the Fort Myer trials of 1908, and was soon experimenting with models powered by rubber bands. Though he had initially planned a career in the US Navy, in 1912 he resigned from the Navy Academy at Annapolis to pursue a career as an aeronautical engineer. Having received the first-ever BSc in



Donald Wills Douglas
(1892-1981)

aeronautical engineering from MIT, Douglas worked for several famous early aircraft companies, including the Glenn Martin Company (he was chief engineer at age 23) and Wright-Martin, before heading the Aviation Section of the US Army Signal Corps. Having rejoined the re-formed Glenn L. Martin Company (for whom he designed the MB-1 bomber), Douglas then formed a partnership with David Davis to create the Davis-Douglas Company in 1920. This was not a

success, and the following year he founded the Douglas Aircraft Company at Santa Monica, California.

Within three years the company had scored a major triumph by supplying the US Army with four “Douglas World Cruisers” for the World Flight project. This was the army’s successful circumnavigation of the globe by air, and it established Douglas as an aircraft manufacturer of note. During the 1920s the company expanded,

producing torpedo bombers for the US Navy, amphibians, observation aircraft, and a dedicated mailplane.

During its early years some of the greatest American aeronautical engineers worked at Douglas, including Jack Northrop, Ed Heinemann, and “Dutch” Kindlerberger. After the crash of a Fokker Trimotor, public confidence in wooden aircraft plummeted, and Douglas responded in 1934 with a radical new design. An all-metal twin-engine machine with a retractable undercarriage, the DC-2 (Douglas Commercial) was more modern than the fixed-undercarriage trimotors, and was an immediate success.

Douglas built 130 DC-2s, and a further 62 as transports for the US military, before coming out with a slightly larger and more powerful version the following year. This was initially designated the Douglas Sleeper Transport, but as most airlines



Passengers aboard a Douglas DC-3

Larger, faster, more economical, and safer than previous passenger aircraft, the DC-3 changed the face of commercial air travel when it was introduced in 1935.

“When you design it, think how you would feel if you had to fly it! Safety first!”

DONALD DOUGLAS

preferred seats to bunks, the 21-seat DC-3 was born. Fast, comfortable, and reliable, this aircraft revolutionized air transport for both the military and civil sectors. General Eisenhower even credited the military version—the C-47—as being one of the four things that won World War II. Eventually, more than 16,000 would be built—dozens still remain in service, although some have been retrofitted with turboprops. Douglas followed this tremendous aircraft with the equally successful DC-4, -6, and -7 propliners, as well as building a wide range of other aircraft. The company also built supersonic research aircraft, with one—the



Defending the democracies

This advertisement for Douglas aircraft from the 1940s celebrates the important role the company played during World War II.

